Distant Close Reading: Measuring Whether a Literature Holds Together

The problem

Organizational scholars argue constantly about whether their literatures cohere, but no one has measured it. Pfeffer (1993) warned that paradigm fragmentation weakens the field; Collins (1998) argues that rivalry among a few positions is how intellectual fields normally work. The disagreement is empirical, yet our instruments do not reach it.

Citation measures such as co-citation and bibliographic coupling record relations between documents, not whether the ideas in them are compatible. Literature reviews reach the ideas, but they compress: hundreds of papers become a few themes, read by one author through one lens. The coherence a review reports cannot be separated from the reading that produced it.

What is missing is a measure of **interpretive coherence**: whether a literature's understanding of its constructs survives being read in deliberately different ways, judged against how much any single way of reading varies on its own.

The method

Distant Close Reading (DCR) makes interpretive variance observable. Language models can be instantiated as readers that are independent, repeatable and specified: each starts fresh, each can be run many times on the same text, and each follows a written method anyone can inspect. No human reader has all three properties. Hermeneutics has long held that different lenses yield different readings (Gadamer, 1960/1989; Ricoeur, 1970). DCR holds a lens fixed and measures the variance it produces.

Two neighbors clarify the claim. Moretti's (2013) distant reading traded close reading for scale; DCR keeps close reading and scales it. Inter-rater reliability measures agreement among coders applying the *same* scheme and treats disagreement as error (Krippendorff, 2004); DCR measures agreement among readers applying *deliberately different* schemes and treats disagreement as signal about the object.

Readers. Three readers apply epistemically distant methods to the same passages, and each produces a different kind of object:

- *Structural:* what must be true for each claim to hold (premises and dependencies).
- *Operational:* what each claim commits one to observing, and what would falsify it.
- *Genealogical:* which earlier formulations the understanding draws on, revises or replaces.

Readers see only passages, a document ID and a year, never authors or titles.

Characterization vs. stance. Each reading is reduced to short standalone claims about what the document takes the construct to be (characterization), plus a separate label for whether it endorses, extends, contests or merely invokes the account it engages (stance). Coherence is computed on

characterization only, because contestation is not incoherence. Critics who describe a construct the same way while disputing it share an understanding.

Measurement. Agreement between claim sets is scored with natural language inference (entailment vs. contradiction), not word similarity. Every comparison is set against a noise floor: the same reader on the same document, repeated. Divergence counts only above that floor.

Editors. Two editors, one synthesizing and one adversarial, read across all readings of a corpus and classify the literature:

	Shared characterization	No shared characterization
Shared stance	Settled	Incoherent consensus
Divided stance	Coherent contestation	Fragmentation

The editors' qualitative judgments are triangulated against the measures. Following Collins's (1998) law of small numbers, a coherently contested field should resolve into a few stable rival positions; incoherent consensus should not.

What we built

We built a working pipeline and ran it in full on two organizational literatures, with every rule committed to Git before results existed.

Corpus. A mechanical rule over OpenAlex selected articles in six journals (AMR, AMJ, ASQ, *Organization Science*, SMJ, JMS) that cite anchor works and name the construct, ranked by citations.

Corpus	Anchors	Documents	Passages
Legitimacy	Suchman (1995); Deephouse & Suchman (2008); Suddaby, Bitektine & Haack (2017)	23	184
Transaction cost economics (TCE)	Williamson (1975, 1981, 1985, 1991)	19	148
Splice: corporate governance	Jensen & Meckling (1976)	5	36

The splice papers use "governance" in an agency-theoretic sense. Adding them to TCE is a manipulation with a known answer. Passages (at most 8 per document, selected by construct terms) are stored as character offsets, so no copyrighted text enters the repository.

Runs. Claude Sonnet 5.5 read every document five times with each of three readers, and the legitimacy and TCE documents also with two sham readers, the structural method reworded in two different voices: 1,125 readings in all. Each reading was reduced to claims (1,125 extractions). Each editor judged each corpus condition once per reader repetition, plus three repeats on fixed input to measure editor variance: 42 editor runs. All 2,292 calls succeeded; 0.4% of extractions failed to parse and were excluded.

Measurement. We compared about 7,100 unique claims with about 860,000 NLI judgments (DeBERTa-large-MNLI; He et al., 2021), within documents (reader vs. reader, and repeat vs. repeat) and between documents (corpus coherence).

Artifact. The repository holds the selection, extraction, run and measurement code; frozen prompts and schemas; manifests with script and text hashes; all extracted claims, editor judgments and measures (full reader outputs, which quote copyrighted text, are available to the editors on request); and a log of every design change with its reason, including one considered and rejected. Anonymized repository: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/distant-close-reading-EDA9/

Validation

Four checks establish that DCR's differences reflect method and literature, not noise or wording.

1. **The measure detects theoretical disagreement.** On 15 author-vetted claim pairs, NLI separated theoretically opposed from equivalent claims perfectly (AUC = 1.00; 14 of 15 labels correct). Embedding similarity inverted the ordering (AUC = 0.18), rating opposed but similarly worded claims as more alike than equivalent ones. Word overlap cannot measure coherence; logical relation can.
2. **Divergence exceeds noise.** Different readers of the same document agreed less (S = 0.256, 95% CI 0.236–0.277) than one reader agreed with its own repetitions (0.325, 0.305–0.343).
3. **Method, not wording, drives divergence.** Sham readers agreed with each other (0.309) and with the structural reader (0.319) at the noise floor. Changing the wording left agreement at the noise floor; changing the method lowered it. The most distant method, genealogical, agreed least with the others.
4. **The instrument responds to known incoherence.** Adding the splice papers lowered TCE coherence from 0.017 to −0.004. Mixed TCE–splice pairs scored lowest (−0.045), while the splice papers agreed among themselves (0.042). Spread across reader repetitions was at most 0.005.

What we found

Legitimacy proved more coherent than TCE (between-document agreement 0.072 vs. 0.017; sd across reader repetitions ≤ 0.004), reversing our prior. The split does not depend on the word: asking readers about "transaction cost economics" instead of "governance" left TCE coherence low (0.025; prespecified check, committed before running, 3 repetitions). In both literatures the loss of coherence is structured, and the structures differ.

TCE splits. Grouping documents after the fact, Williamson's works agree with one another (mean 0.128, 10 pairs), as do relational-governance papers (0.109, 3 pairs). Between the two groups, agreement falls to 0.011, near the TCE average. Coherence collapses where "governance" changes what it is, its unit, and its criterion:

Document	Governance is…	Unit	Criterion or mechanism
Williamson (1991)	One of three discrete structures: market, hybrid, hierarchy	The transaction	Efficiency, matched to asset specificity

Document	Governance is…	Unit	Criterion or mechanism
Ring & Van de Ven (1994)	A developmental process of negotiation, commitment and execution	The relationship over time	Efficiency and equity; trust
Eisenhardt & Schoonhoven (1996)	A firm's strategic choice to ally, not theorized as governance	The firm	Resource needs and social position

Agreement with Williamson falls from 0.045 (Ring & Van de Ven) to −0.104 (Eisenhardt & Schoonhoven), among the lowest in the corpus. TCE's organizing term travels through management under one name and several meanings. A careful reviewer of TCE might notice this split; DCR measures it, places it on one scale with another literature, and lets anyone rerun it.

Legitimacy fades rather than splits. Its theorizing core is most coherent (Suchman, 1995: 0.138), declining toward papers that invoke legitimacy as a motive, such as CSR reporting (Marquis & Qian, 2014: 0.012). Stance is uniform: readers judged 18 of 23 documents to modify and 5 to extend the account they engage. TCE stances spread across extend (9), modify (7), contest (2) and endorse (1).

Editors are reliable but coarse. On fixed input, each editor repeated its own judgment in all 16 runs. But editors labeled 29 of 30 main runs "coherent contestation", so the measures, not the labels, distinguish the literatures. Editors did register the splice, adding positions (adversarial: 5.0 to 6.2; synthesizing: 5.2 to 5.6), and the adversarial editor found 5.4 positions in legitimacy and 5.0 in TCE, within the three-to-six range Collins (1998) predicts.

Beyond citations. Agreement between document pairs correlated moderately with bibliographic coupling (Spearman $\rho = 0.43$ for legitimacy, 0.26 for TCE). Shared references account for part of interpretive agreement; most of it is not visible in citation structure.

Every number traces to text. Each claim in the table links to the passages it rests on, and each passage to its page and character offsets in the repository.

Key risks and limitations

- **One model family, default sampling.** All runs used Claude Sonnet 5.5 through Claude Code, which does not expose temperature. Measured stability may partly reflect this model. Cross-model replication is the first Stage 2 test.
- **NLI sometimes reads contrast as contradiction.** Repeated readings by one reader show a conflict ratio of 0.65. A prespecified diagnostic (committed before running) on 10 compatible-but-different claim pairs found the bias real but limited: 2 were labeled contradictory, both contrasting sibling categories (cognitive vs. pragmatic legitimacy; hierarchies vs. markets), and none entailment. The high ratio mostly reflects that distinct claims rarely entail each other. Absolute agreement is deflated; comparisons survive because every condition shares the bias.
- **Extraction normalizes voice.** Stripping method vocabulary lets the measures compare content, but it could also make readings converge artificially. The sham control and noise floor bound this risk; they do not remove it.

- **A small, curated corpus, one thin document.** Forty-seven documents make results checkable by experts, not general. One PDF turned out to be a first-page preview; we caught it because its claims scored as unusually coherent, replaced it, and reran all 76 dependent calls.
- **NLI lacks domain knowledge.** The one gold-pair error ("bounded rationality" vs. "people cannot foresee every contingency") shows a general-purpose NLI model can miss inferences specialists make.
- **Readers may recognize famous papers.** Blinding readers to authors and titles limits recall from memory but cannot prevent it.

Stage 2

The prototype asks whether interpretive coherence can be measured at all. Stage 2 asks how far the measure travels.

1. **Cross-model replication.** Rerun the full design on an open-weights model with controlled sampling. A stability pattern that replicates across model families is evidence about the literature, not the model.
2. **Scale.** Extend to 200 or more documents per literature, and to further literatures expected to differ in coherence, such as institutional logics and organizational identity.
3. **The cluster-count test.** Test whether coherently contested literatures resolve into the small number of stable positions that Collins's law of small numbers predicts.
4. **A reader library.** A reader is a prompt plus an output schema, so the architecture is modular. We will add readers (for example, contrastive and temporal) and invite the community to contribute others.
5. **Expert-labeled claims.** Build a larger gold set with domain experts, to calibrate NLI on organizational theory.
6. **Design choices, refined with the editors.** Construct terms, reader sets and editor roles are parameters we expect to refine at the workshop.

How organizational science changes

If DCR works, coherence becomes something organizational scholars can measure rather than assert. The debate over whether the field is fragmented (Pfeffer, 1993) or productively rivalrous (Collins, 1998) gains an instrument. The answer can differ by literature, and that is the point.

Three practical shifts follow. Reviews can report how robust their synthesis is to the way it was read, much as quantitative work reports robustness checks. Contested constructs can be diagnosed: a field arguing about a construct it shares can be told apart from one using a shared word for different things. And theory building gains a map of where a literature's agreement is real and where it is nominal.

The broader shift is from literature synthesis to literature deliberation. Disagreement stops being noise a reviewer resolves and becomes a property of a field that can be observed, compared and tracked over time.

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